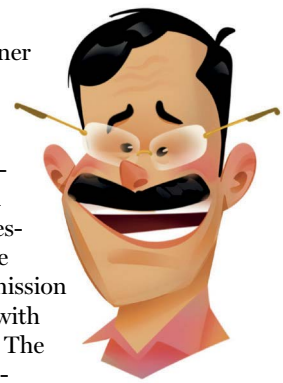
DYNASTY LEAGUE



Union agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan's son **Kartikey Chouhan** was elected unopposed as president of the Madhya Pradesh Volleyball Association on October 11. He follows **Mahanaryamaan Scindia**, son of Union minister Jyotiraditya Scindia, who earlier became president of the MP Cricket Association. Both are active in their fathers' constituencies and appear to harbour political ambitions. Chouhan Sr and Scindia Sr had forged a strong bond between 2020 and 2023, when the former was CM. That understanding, perhaps, has now found a new arena with the juniors heading major sports bodies.



CLEAN-UP COMMISSAR



Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) commissioner **Tukaram Mundhe**, whose relentless crackdown rattled the state's food and hospitality sectors, has been handed another sensitive assignment. The 2005 batch IAS officer will head the panel investigating alleged irregularities at the Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC), an institution entrusted with recruiting the state's civil servants. The appointment also raises an intriguing question: has Mundhe become the Maharashtra government's go-to troubleshooter whenever a department or institution finds itself in a soup?

STING THEORY



Earlier this month, KarnatakaCM **D.K. Shivakumar** warned his ministers about purported sting operations, claiming he himself had been targeted soon after taking office in June. "I know who is behind this, who is the *pitamaha* financing it," he declared, without naming anyone. Political rival and Union minister H.D. Kumaraswamy of the Janata Dal (Secular) was quick to demand answers. If the CM himself had been targeted by a sting operation, Kumaraswamy argued, he must reveal what happened. After all, the public had a right to know.

Kaushik Deka* with *Prasad Nichenametla, Jumana Shah, Ashish Misra, Rahul Noronha, Dhaval S. Kulkarni* and *Ajay Sukumaran

ECO WATCH

GLOBAL WILDLIFE NUMBERS

INDIAN BIG CATS BEAT ODDS

By **Jumana Shah**

Monitored wildlife populations worldwide have shrunk by an average of 73 per cent since 1970, according to the Living Planet Report 2026, published by the World Wide Fund for Nature. The index draws on 35,803 population trends across 5,790 species of mammals, birds, amphibians, reptiles and fish. The figure is an average change in population size, not a count of animals lost. Some populations have collapsed while others have grown, and the index averages the two. Freshwater life fared the worst, with an average fall of 85 per cent, the steepest drop in the index. The picture is not uniformly bleak. Half of the populations tracked are stable or increasing. But the declines outweigh the gains, which is why the average still reads a fall of 73 per cent.

India supplies several of the report's bright spots. Wild tiger numbers worldwide rose from about 3,200 in 2010 to around 5,700 in 2025, with India's last official count, from 2022, at 3,682. Asiatic lions grew from 674 in 2020 to 891 in 2025, and the country's first range-wide survey estimated 6,324 Ganges river dolphins.

Habitat loss is the most imminent threat, with the WWF saying conservation alone cannot reverse the losses. It blames the food, energy and finance systems behind it. India is on a strong wicket here, having done remarkably well in renewable energy. The report says India has taken a lead among other countries in two- and three-wheeler EV section to boost economy. Sejal Worah, programme director at WWF-India, says, "India has taken significant leadership in energy, and there is movement in redesigning agriculture too. Despite the challenges, the solutions are there."

